

# Biopsychosocial Assessment

Learner guide | SWP-004 | School of Mental Health & Clinical Practice

This guide supports a three-part learning sequence for Biopsychosocial Assessment. By the end of the course, you should be able to conduct a collaborative, ethical whole-person assessment and formulate priority needs.

Practice notice: Apply the law, organisational policy, supervision requirements, and approved referral pathways that govern your setting. This material supports learning and does not replace urgent safeguarding, clinical, or legal procedures.

## Learning objectives

- Conduct a collaborative, ethical whole-person assessment and formulate priority needs.
- Apply the key ideas from Assessment framework.
- Apply the key ideas from Risk and formulation.
- Apply the key ideas from From assessment to plan.

## Course structure

| Module                     | Focus                                                                                                      | Suggested study time |
|----------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------|
| 1. Assessment framework    | engagement, consent, presenting concerns, biological/psychological/social domains, and strengths           | 10 to 15 minutes     |
| 2. Risk and formulation    | mental-state observation, suicide/self-harm and safeguarding screening, cultural humility, and formulation | 10 to 15 minutes     |
| 3. From assessment to plan | goals, referrals, documentation, review, and simulated intake                                              | 10 to 15 minutes     |

# Module 1 Assessment framework

This module focuses on engagement, consent, presenting concerns, biological/psychological/social domains, and strengths. Work through the material with a current practice setting in mind, but remove identifying information from any examples you record.

## What to pay attention to

- Engagement
- Consent
- Presenting concerns
- Biological/psychological/social domains
- Strengths

## Learning sequence

Start by defining the purpose of assessment framework in relation to the course outcome. Notice where professional judgement is needed and where a local procedure must guide the next step.

Examine the practical implications of engagement, consent, presenting concerns, biological/psychological/social domains, and strengths. Separate observations from assumptions, identify strengths as well as concerns, and be clear about information that must be checked with a person, family, colleague, or approved source.

Use a respectful, collaborative approach. Explain your role, seek informed participation where appropriate, and document only information that is relevant, accurate, and necessary for the purpose of the work.

When a concern exceeds your role, supervision, competence, or authority, pause and use the correct escalation route. A prompt referral and a clear handover can protect continuity of support.

## Practice reflection

Choose a de-identified practice situation. What information would help you work through assessment framework safely, and what would require consultation or a local policy check?

## Module 2 Risk and formulation

This module focuses on mental-state observation, suicide/self-harm and safeguarding screening, cultural humility, and formulation. Work through the material with a current practice setting in mind, but remove identifying information from any examples you record.

### What to pay attention to

- Mental-state observation
- Suicide/self-harm
- Safeguarding screening
- Cultural humility
- Formulation

### Learning sequence

Start by defining the purpose of risk and formulation in relation to the course outcome. Notice where professional judgement is needed and where a local procedure must guide the next step.

Examine the practical implications of mental-state observation, suicide/self-harm and safeguarding screening, cultural humility, and formulation. Separate observations from assumptions, identify strengths as well as concerns, and be clear about information that must be checked with a person, family, colleague, or approved source.

Use a respectful, collaborative approach. Explain your role, seek informed participation where appropriate, and document only information that is relevant, accurate, and necessary for the purpose of the work.

When a concern exceeds your role, supervision, competence, or authority, pause and use the correct escalation route. A prompt referral and a clear handover can protect continuity of support.

### Practice reflection

Choose a de-identified practice situation. What information would help you work through risk and formulation safely, and what would require consultation or a local policy check?

## Module 3 From assessment to plan

This module focuses on goals, referrals, documentation, review, and simulated intake. Work through the material with a current practice setting in mind, but remove identifying information from any examples you record.

### What to pay attention to

- Goals
- Referrals
- Documentation
- Review
- Simulated intake

### Learning sequence

Start by defining the purpose of from assessment to plan in relation to the course outcome. Notice where professional judgement is needed and where a local procedure must guide the next step.

Examine the practical implications of goals, referrals, documentation, review, and simulated intake. Separate observations from assumptions, identify strengths as well as concerns, and be clear about information that must be checked with a person, family, colleague, or approved source.

Use a respectful, collaborative approach. Explain your role, seek informed participation where appropriate, and document only information that is relevant, accurate, and necessary for the purpose of the work.

When a concern exceeds your role, supervision, competence, or authority, pause and use the correct escalation route. A prompt referral and a clear handover can protect continuity of support.

### Practice reflection

Choose a de-identified practice situation. What information would help you work through from assessment to plan safely, and what would require consultation or a local policy check?

## Course activity

Use the accompanying worksheet to apply the course sequence to a short case. Your completed activity should show what you noticed, the action you would take within your role, and what you would escalate or verify locally.

## Assessment preparation

- Review the distinction between: domains.
- Review the distinction between: risk escalation.
- Review the distinction between: formulation.
- Review the distinction between: documentation.

## References and local adaptation

- SWEEP Academy Course Content Outlines, production blueprint for this course.
- The current legislation, professional standards, safeguarding procedures, and referral directories for the delivery jurisdiction.
- The learner's employer or placement policy, supervision arrangements, and documentation standards.